

AN ESSAY

I Built It Anyway

by Sarah Hitchcox, RN, BSN



SARAH HITCHCOX, RN, BSN

There is never a good time. That is the thing nobody tells you, and it is the thing I most want to pass on.

The year we started, everything happened at once. We got married. We found out I was pregnant. We moved into a new house. And my husband, a web developer, lost his job in the tech layoffs, all in the same twelve months. That was the year I decided to open my own practice. Not because it was a smart time. There was no smart time. It was sink or swim, and we swam because the other option was not really an option.

People who loved us told us not to do it. Some told us outright that we would fail. I understand why. On paper it looked reckless: a pregnant nurse in graduate school starting a business while her household's steady paycheck disappeared. Every practical voice, including the one in my own head at two in the morning, said the same thing: not now. Wait until school is done. Wait until the baby comes. Wait until things settle.

I did not wait, and that decision taught me more than any classroom ever has.

The truth is there had never been a good time, not once, and I had built things anyway. I put myself through school working as a nursing assistant in an emergency room. Class all day, night shift after, and most weeks I was awake thirty-six hours straight. The ER nurses

took me under their wings and gave me real responsibility, and I learned more in those overnight hours than I ever did in a lecture hall. That was also when I met my husband. The pattern was set early: everything I have, I built tired, in the margins, long before I ever felt ready.

Nursing teaches you a particular kind of competence. You learn to walk into a room where things are going wrong, sort what matters from what does not, and act. You learn that hesitation has a cost. What nursing does not teach you is how to believe that this competence belongs to you, that it can be the foundation of something you build yourself rather than something you rent out by the shift. Hospitals are good at making you feel replaceable. It took me years to see that the only thing separating me from the people who owned their own practices was that they had started theirs.

So I started. Small, and scared, and pregnant. We had a grand opening. I bought cupcakes and made up little treat bags and set everything out, and nobody came. We opened the next morning anyway. Nothing about a business begins at the ribbon. It begins with the next client, and the next, and the slow accumulation of trust that is the only real currency a practice has. My husband built the website. He also went to work in his family's business while ours got on its feet, and that is where he learned how a small company actually runs, week to week and dollar to dollar. We could not have built ours without that education.



THE STUDIO IN BEARDEN, KNOXVILLE

Here is what surprised me most: motherhood did not shrink my capacity. Everyone warned me it would. Instead it clarified it. When your time stops being your own, you stop spending it carelessly. I became ruthless about what deserved my hours. The business got the best of

me in the hours it had, because there were no spare hours to waste on doubt. I do not recommend the hard way for its own sake. But I no longer believe the myth that you must clear your life before you build something in it. The clearing never comes. Life does not hand anyone an empty calendar and say, *Now!*

And Knoxville met us halfway. Clients sent their friends, then their mothers and their daughters. We showed up at the community's events and got to know the city we were asking to trust us. There was no applause along the way. There was just a schedule that kept quietly filling, week after week, which is the only applause a small business ever really needs. In a city like this your reputation is the business, and it is built one kept promise at a time.

The last thing, the one I would put on a billboard if I could: experience is a teacher, and waiting is not. Every mistake I made in the first year, and there were plenty, taught me something I still use. The time I spent waiting to feel ready taught me nothing except how to wait. If I had postponed until the sensible moment, I would still be postponing. Readiness is not a feeling you wait for. It is a skill you earn by starting before you have it.



THE FINISH LINE, WITH THE PEOPLE IT WAS FOR

I think about our kids watching all of this. Our oldest was there, in a literal sense, at the founding. Two months after our second was born I ran my first race, the half at the Covenant Health Knoxville Marathon, and this spring they watched me finish my first full marathon, trained for in the margins of this same life: two kids, graduate school, two locations, a schedule with no slack in it. Somewhere past mile twenty I understood that the race was the business in miniature. Both have a long stretch in the middle where you are

working as hard as you can and getting nowhere you can see. For most of our first years we were still losing money every month while we worked every hour we had, and it felt like we would never get there. You cannot stop, either, because people are depending on you, and there is no version of a marathon where you sit down for a while and pick it back up later. So you keep running, past the point where it feels sensible, past the point where you can picture the end, until one day the schedule is full and the bills are paid and you understand that the finish line was never a moment. It was every mile you ran when nothing told you that you were close. I hope that is what our children absorb, not that their mother worked too much, though some seasons I surely did, but that a woman can look at her one crowded, imperfect, inconvenient life and decide to build something in the middle of it anyway. Not after the degree. Not after the babies. Not once everything settles. In the middle of it, with a full heart and a full calendar and no guarantee at all.

There is never a good time. There is only your time, the years you are actually given, crowded with all the things you are already carrying. Start smaller than you dreamed, scared as you are, in the life you already have. The confidence you are waiting to feel is not at the start line. It is somewhere in the miles, and you only find it by running them.



THE ASHEVILLE MARATHON, MARCH 2026

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